into the mercantile Balija caste in Erode in what was then the Madras Presidency in 1879.

After experiencing Brahminical discrimination at first hand while on a pilgrimage to Benares, Periyar became a militant atheist, arguing with ever-increasing fervour that Hinduism was an imaginary faith that promoted the superiority of the Brahmins at great cost to the Shudras and Dalits. Some of his actions – such as his frequently stated belief that continuing British rule was preferable to *Swaraj*, or 'self-rule', if that meant government by a Hindi-speaking Congress; his burning of a picture of Rama as a symbol of Arya domination of the Dravidians; his statement that 'He who invented God is a fool, he who propagates God is a scoundrel, he who worships God is a barbarian'; or even his suggestion that Hindus who found themselves marginalised should consider converting to Buddhism, Christianity or Islam – would today get him into very hot water.

Periyar's ardent Tamil nationalism combined with his atheism and his anti-Brahminism won him many admirers. Some of those same admirers, however, turned to violence, which led considerable numbers of Brahmins in Kerala and Tamil Nadu to make the decision to pack their bags and migrate out of Tamil country. Today only 3 per cent of the population in those two states are Brahmins – to my mind, a great loss to the South. For all the privileges they awarded themselves and for all the discrimination that this engendered, the Brahmins were and still are a quite extraordinary phenomenon, not just as keepers of the Vedic flame over millennia but as a small cadre of largely unsung intellectuals, scientists and healers whose learning brought great lustre to their culture. Consider, for example, the extraordinary work of the medieval astronomers and mathematicians of Kerala between the fourteenth and sixteenth centuries who, among other achievements, invented calculus a couple of centuries before their